

Standard Treatment Guidelines and Essential Medicines List for South Africa

**Primary Healthcare Level
2024 Edition**



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NOTE:

The information presented in these guidelines conforms to the current medical, nursing and pharmaceutical practice. Contributors and editors cannot be held responsible for errors, individual responses to medicines and other consequences.

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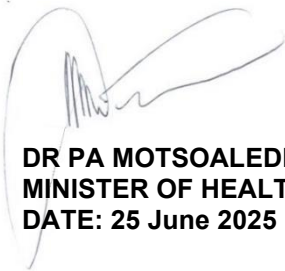
FOREWORD

I proudly present the updated 2024 editions of both the Primary Healthcare (PHC) and Adult Hospital Level (AHL) Standard Treatment Guidelines (STGs) and Essential Medicines List (EML). These guidelines aim to enhance transparency and support the delivery of high-quality treatment options at both PHC and hospital levels. They reflect the evolving clinical needs of our population as well as the introduction of new medicines.

Universal Health Coverage (UHC) aims to eliminate disparities in healthcare access and outcomes, providing financial protection and access to quality healthcare for all South Africans, as mandated by the constitution of South Africa. The National Essential Medicines List Committee (NEMLC) has incrementally increased the use of Health Technology Assessment processes in the selection of essential medicines, providing transparent priority-setting and value-based guidance for efficient resource allocation. The PHC and AHL STGs and EML are a key pillar of UHC, laying the groundwork for structuring health service benefits and ensuring equitable access to safe, effective and affordable medicines for all.

I commend the diligent work of the PHC and AHL Expert Review Committee (ERC), along with the NEMLC, in developing the 2024 editions of the PHC and AHL STGs and EML according to good governance and evidence-based decision principles.

I encourage stakeholders across all sectors to actively participate in the continuous review, development and implementation of these guidelines. I encourage engagement with the NEMLC process of STG development through the external comment process. I appreciate your engagement in presentations and webinars hosted by the NDoH, as well as dissemination of communication published on the National Department of Health web page. Your active involvement is crucial for the successful implementation of these STGs and the improvement of health outcomes for our nation.



DR PA MOTSOALEDI, MP
MINISTER OF HEALTH
DATE: 25 June 2025

INTRODUCTION

The Primary Healthcare (PHC) and Adult Hospital Level (AHL) Standard Treatment Guidelines (STGs) and Essential Medicines List (EML) enable the equitable access to safe, effective and affordable essential medicines across South Africa.

Historically, the PHC and AHL Expert Review Committees (ERCs) responsible for developing the PHC and AHL STGs were appointed as separate Committees. However, in 2020 the Committees were merged to streamline efforts and optimise resources, ensuring a seamless continuum of care between the PHC and AHL of care. The review cycle for these STGs commenced at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, necessitating a shift in priorities to address emerging needs and challenges faced by the healthcare system during the pandemic.

The ERC reviews the STGs and EML according to a topic prioritisation framework that includes consideration of clinical need, efficacy, safety, cost-effectiveness, feasibility and equity, presenting recommendations to the National Essential Medicines List Committee (NEMLC) for appraisal and ratification. The multidisciplinary team, which includes clinical experts, clinical pharmacologists and evidence-review and guideline-development methodologists has strengthened the STG development process. The National Department of Health's Essential Drugs Programme team supports this process and has ensured collaboration and alignment with other advisory groups in updating these guidelines.

The NEMLC has incorporated the latest advances in clinical care into various disorder and chapter updates, expanding medicine treatment options including (but not limited to) Blood and Blood-Forming Organs, HIV, Mental Health, Obstetrics and Gynaecology, as well as Palliative Care. Notably, the AHL STGs and EML features a new chapter on Adult Critical Care, developed through extensive consultation across both public and private sectors. This chapter aims to enhance our response capabilities and ensure comprehensive care for critically ill patients.

The 2024 editions of the PHC and AHL STGs and EML reflects the National Department of Health's commitment to continually evolving and enhancing the quality and accessibility of healthcare across our country.



DR SSS BUTHELEZI
DIRECTOR-GENERAL: HEALTH
DATE: 11 June 2025

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The publication of this edition of the Primary Healthcare (PHC) Standard Treatment Guidelines (STGs) and Essential Medicines List (EML) is testament of the enthusiasm, dedication, technical expertise and time given by the National Department of Health Essential Drugs Programme, the combined PHC/Adult Hospital Level Expert Review Committee and the National Essential Medicines List Committee (NEMLC). For continuum of care, the PHC STGs have been aligned with the approved NEMLC recommendations contained in the Adult Hospital Level (2024 edition), Paediatric Hospital Level (2023 edition) STGs and EML, in collaboration with the National Department of Health Programmatic Guidelines. The quality of this edition was further enhanced by the constructive collaboration with various stakeholders through the public comment stages of the 2020-2024 STG and EML review cycle.

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THE ESSENTIAL MEDICINES CONCEPT

The WHO describes Essential medicines as those that satisfy the priority health care needs of the population. Essential medicines are intended to be available within the context of functioning health systems at all times in adequate quantities, in the appropriate dosage forms, with assured quality and adequate information, and at a price the individual and the community can afford.

The concept of essential medicines is forward-looking. It incorporates the need to regularly update medicines selections to:

- » reflect new therapeutic options and changing therapeutic needs;
- » the need to ensure medicine quality; and
- » the need for continued development of better medicines, medicines for emerging diseases, and medicines to meet changing resistance patterns.

Effective health care requires a judicious balance between preventive and curative services. A crucial and often deficient element in curative services is an adequate supply of appropriate medicines. In the health objectives of the National Drug Policy, the government of South Africa clearly outlines its commitment to ensuring availability and accessibility of medicines for all people. These are as follows:

- » To ensure the availability and accessibility of essential medicines to all citizens.
- » To ensure the safety, efficacy and quality of medicines.
- » To ensure good prescribing and dispensing practices.
- » To promote the rational use of medicines by prescribers, dispensers and patients through provision of the necessary training, education and information.
- » To promote the concept of individual responsibility for health, preventive care and informed decision-making.

Achieving these objectives requires a comprehensive strategy that not only includes improved supply and distribution, but also appropriate and extensive human resource development. The implementation of an Essential Drugs Programme (EDP) forms an integral part of this strategy, with continued rationalisation of the variety of medicines available in the public sector as a first priority. The private sector is encouraged to use these guidelines and medicine list wherever appropriate.

The criteria for the selection of essential medicines for Primary Health Care in South Africa were based on the WHO guidelines for drawing up a national EML. Essential medicines are selected with due regard to disease prevalence, evidence on efficacy and safety, and comparative cost.

The implementation of the concept of essential medicines is intended to be flexible and adaptable to many different situations. It remains a national responsibility to determine which medicines are regarded as essential.

HOW TO USE THESE GUIDELINES

Principles

The National Drug Policy¹ provides for an Essential Drugs Programme (EDP) - a key component of promoting rational medicines use. Medicines are included or removed from the Essential Medicines List (EML) following an evidence-based review of safety and effectiveness and considering cost and other relevant practice factors. The review process is dynamic, and starts with prioritisation of chapters, medicines, or disease areas. The EML, STGs, and the reviews informing them are then updated and published on an ongoing basis. Each new review or update involves seeking input and comments from external stakeholders. Stakeholders are also given opportunity to input prior to final publication. All reasonable steps are taken to align the Standard Treatment Guidelines (STGs) with Department of Health guidelines available at the time of review. Some recommendations might not be aligned with the indications or doses included in South African Health Products Regulatory Authority (SAHPRA) approved professional information but are guided by the best available scientific evidence.

The perspective adopted in the Primary Healthcare (PHC) STGs is that of a competent authorised prescriber practising in a public sector facility. The STGs serve as a standard for practice but do not replace sound clinical judgment. It is important to remember that the treatments recommended are guidelines only, based on the assumption that prescribers can manage patients with the relevant conditions. This includes rational prescribing in the elderly and palliative care, as the use of some medicines, especially as people get older or more ill, can cause more harm than good. Optimizing medication use through targeted de-prescribing is vital in managing chronic conditions, avoiding adverse effects, improving outcomes, reducing pill burden, and maintaining or improving quality of life.

The PHC EML and STGs allow for managing patients with relatively common conditions at the primary level of care. They also guide the referral of patients with more complex or uncommon conditions to facilities with the skills and resources to provide further investigation and management. As such, they are a progression to the Adult and Paediatric hospital-level EMLs and STGs.

The PHC STGs and EML should be used by healthcare workers providing care at clinics, community health centres, mobile clinics, outreach programmes, and gateway or out-patient clinics at hospitals.

Pharmaceutical and Therapeutics Committees (PTCs) are the primary implementing bodies of medicine-related governance in the provinces, districts and health establishments in South Africa. They are a crucial component of the medicine supply chain as the custodians of medicine governance and the rational selection and use of medicines at all levels of

¹ National Drugs Policy, 1996. <https://www.gov.za/documents/national-drugs-policy>